

KF44 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Let’s continue our training in **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. By closing off one nostril we impose a limitation on ourselves that we can explore. Breathing is life support. What does closing off half of your life support feel like? This meditation does a lot of great things for our brains and bodies, but it also gives us an opportunity to explore a little controlled stress.

Let’s begin with a body scan to connect our minds to our marvelous bodies. Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for twenty seconds, allowing your body to regulate your breath. *(Pause for 20 seconds)*

Now turn your attention to your feet and ankles. What sensations do you notice there? *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Take a deep breath and move your attention to your calves and knees. Do you notice any discomfort, pain, or perhaps twitching? Breathe and observe. Try to relax on the exhale. *(Pause of 20 seconds)*

Now begin to observe your thighs and hips. What do you notice? On the exhale, release any tension or discomfort you find there. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Move your attention to your torso. Scan your abdomen, chest, and back. Observe, and then release with the breath any tension you find. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Now scan your neck and shoulders, arms and hands. Breathe, adjust, and release any tension. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Observe your face. Breathe and relax any tightness or tension. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Now we will move to **Alternate Nostril Breathing**.

Begin to breathe using alternate nostrils. You can breathe naturally or combine this training with another meditation technique. You may wish to pause at the top and bottom of the breath. Practice for three

minutes. I will give you one-minute markers. *(Pause for 3 minutes, announcing each minute as it passes)*

Take a deep breath and pause. Notice how your body feels. *(Pause)* How does your mind feel? *(Pause)* In your own meditation time, you might try this method for five minutes, or for as long as you wish, and then explore the results.

Our hymn for KF Confession 10, *O Worship the King*, describes our real condition. We are human creatures who are as frail as dust and learning to trust God.

Frail children of dust, and feeble as frail
In Thee do we trust, nor find Thee to fail.
Thy mercies how tender, how firm to the end,
Our Maker, Defender, Redeemer, and Friend.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 10 reminds us of our design and our dependence on our real Creator:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

All of us are subject to the limitations of money, abilities, time, and health. That’s why we are learning to do the MATH. Doing the MATH helps us set priorities about what we will do with our limited resources. Decision-making is so much easier when we have clearly defined priorities. Priorities allow us to communicate honestly and consistently. We become more certain about our preferences and are not so easily jerked around by our immediate circumstances. For example, a husband and wife went to a Broadway show. The show was well done, but at the intermission they found it easy to make the decision to go home. Their priority was to feel rested for the next day’s work, and they weren’t willing to jeopardize their limited health resources by forfeiting their sleep.

With clear priorities, you can more easily decide to leave food on the plate, walk away from a conversation or an addictive behavior, get up earlier or go to bed earlier, plan a day that doesn’t include TV, book a flight that leaves after your workout, leave a project undone to cuddle on the couch with someone you love, resist bargain shopping, or refuse the myriad of other drains on your resources that leave you in debt. By doing the MATH and setting your priorities, you take control of your life. Then, when people or situations make demands on your money, abilities, time, or health, you don’t have to waste energy considering how to respond, and you won’t have to waste resources recovering from impulsive choices.

Just as we need to be realistic about our health, we need to be realistic about our abilities, which are also subject to limitations. Our mindfulness training equips us to observe our real abilities without making judgments or comparisons. Rather than pursuing what we imagine we could do or think we should do, we can look at what we are already doing and what we can learn today. I encourage you to cultivate the humility of an open mind and allow God to train you. If you cannot appreciate your real abilities and limitations, you will default to the illusions of your Idol Self—to what you think you could, or should, be

or do; you will revert to your search for the idealized *Glory of Me!*

For many decades, my pride would not allow me to do my MATH and then honor and work within the limitations of my abilities. As a result, I made my own life and the lives of others unnecessarily burdensome and painful. I wish I had been able to patiently explore and develop my real abilities. I have bought houses that I couldn't take care of, volunteered for jobs that I wasn't qualified to do, agreed to take on responsibilities that made my life miserable with anxiety, and presented myself to others as a person who could do anything they might ask. What little ability I had was constantly taxed and overwhelmed by the situations I got myself into. The successful navigation of these situations required resources, skills, experience, and substantial personal development that I did not possess. I could not learn to swim because I was spending all my energy just keeping my head above water.

If we are misoriented and not mindful, we voluntarily participate in situations that we are not equipped to handle. Then, when we discover that we are not equal to the task and find ourselves drowning in chaotic emotions and consequences, we try to salvage our pride by imposing neurotic claims on life and on others. We are now in survival mode and on the defensive. Feelings and behavior become extreme, and we are reduced to scrambling around for stratagems that will allow us to maintain our illusions and avoid self-hate.

Mastery types believe that they can accomplish anything with enough willpower or information. When failure threatens, they blame God, others, or circumstances. They completely ignore the facts and imagine ability or success where none is evident. They might, for example, try to teach something when they themselves are not competent in that area. The disparity is apparent to those around them, but they are unable to see it for themselves. If mastery types judge a situation as hopeless, or if their ill-preparedness is exposed, they will assert that God or circumstances have been against them. In their imagined superiority they may claim that they are exempt from any need to prepare and then expect others to accommodate them. They cannot see that they simply are not equal to the challenge, so they tell a virtue story about how they could be competent "if only".

Self-effacing types ignore their real abilities and sign up for situations that showcase their weaknesses. They need experiences that reinforce their belief that they are losers and victims, so they will undermine their own real development and disregard or abhor their real strengths and potential. They feel compelled to accommodate others in order to elicit love or appreciation based solely on how nice or available they are. Their real abilities lie fallow because for them any self-development feels expansive and terrifying.

Resigned people underestimate their potential because exploring their opportunities would invite change and involve risk and effort. Their fear of personal imposition and loss of freedom compels them to avoid making a karis contribution to their community—a contribution that requires the integration of emotional health with developed ability. Since their emotions are locked up, so are their abilities, and they find themselves living far below the potential of their design.

When you are doing the MATH, look at your real abilities. What are you doing successfully right now? What are your antecedents and education? What is your natural design? When your MATH cannot support an undertaking, explore. You might ask yourself: "Is this where I belong? Do my design and antecedents support this undertaking? Am I driven by the fear of hurt pride or, perhaps, by compulsive needs?" Ask, Seek, and Knock. Get help. Enlist others to help you do the MATH. It is essential for your mission that you develop your real strengths and learn to use them. Your strengths will help you understand your role in the Creation.

Working out of your real abilities helps you flow through life. Think of how much more ability you have since you began KF training. When you grow your abilities, you need fewer resources to do your work. You then have more MATH available for circulating your real gifts and developing your real glory—and you will have more fun in the process.

Our prayer might go something like this:

My Father, help me explore my real strengths and learn how to develop them. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

In the community of Christ, each one of us is equally necessary. Your abilities may be similar to those of others, but as you exercise your abilities through your own design, the purpose of God is accomplished through you in a unique way. There is no one like you, with your particular design and antecedents. No one can do what you do the way that you do it. That is what makes you a valuable player in the business of expressing God’s glory. Only you are designed to do what you do.

When we live in the Idol’s system, we are driven to achieve an imagined glory that we believe will satisfy our pride and fulfill the longing for the *Glory of Me!* We have a compelling need to lift ourselves above others and feel safe in our superiority. We compare ourselves to others and envy the roles we watch them play.² We want what others have, mostly because we do not value what we ourselves have. We may even judge our strengths to be loathsome or worthless because we hate the actual creature that we are—and, of course, we will actively avoid exploring, learning about, and training something that we already hate.

God, however, wants you to discover the glory of His creation. He wants you to reveal the person He created you to be, which is most particularly developed and displayed in the midst of your limitations. Your Father wants to train your strengths while He trains your character. To do this, He has to lead you into the struggle of discovery, which reveals to you what you actually have to offer and builds the foundation of a confident, stable character. This process has nothing to do with effortless superiority. Effort is essential. Superior abilities alone will not generate the confidence we seek. Without courageous, oriented, real endurance in the struggle, you will not have the character to sustain the possibilities of your God-designed glory. Remember that your productive struggle with limitations is very valuable. It is part of your portion, and you can expect your courageous struggle to fulfill its purpose, which is to make you mature, complete, and fully equipped for your mission.³

In the following passage, Paul wants to help us understand how important it is for each one of us to use our abilities to fulfill our unique design within our particular portion. This is my paraphrase of **First Corinthians 12:13–20**.

¹³Let me explain how each one of us, no matter what our backgrounds or social status might be, is equally necessary in the Body of Christ. By one Spirit we all are immersed into one body, whether we are Jews, Greeks, slaves, or freeborn. We are given one Spirit to

drink.¹⁴You can look at it this way: even your own body is not one part, but many parts, and God designed it that way. ¹⁵If your foot should say, “Because I am not the hand, I am not part of the body,” the foot does not cease to be part of the body because of that belief. ¹⁶And if the ear were to say, “Because I am not the eye, I am not part of the body,” the eye does not, just by saying this, cease to be part of the body. ¹⁷If the whole body were an eye, how could it hear? If all the parts of the body were trying to hear, how would the body be able to smell? ¹⁸Just as God intended the different parts of our physical body to cooperate with and complement each other, so He has placed each individual person in the body of Christ to work together with other individuals, each performing their unique function. ¹⁹If those individuals were all one member, where would the fully functioning body be? ²⁰There are many different backgrounds and social positions, but now that the Spirit has come, all who trust are of one body.

Take a deep breath.

Although Paul is teaching us a principle about the Body of Christ, we can apply the same principle to the entire human community. We are God’s creatures, and just like all other creatures, we, live in an ecosystem and have a part to play in helping the Creation flow efficiently. Those of us who are in Christ, however, have the greatest potential to influence the human community because we are invited to cooperate with God.

God influenced the powerful nation of Egypt through the cooperation of one man, Joseph. You can read this story in the book of Genesis.⁴ Joseph was sold as a slave and yet became a ruler in the greatest empire of his time. Joseph had abilities, but as a young man he lacked the character and trustworthiness required to fulfill his mission. His difficult life circumstances could have made him bitter, but he trusted God, his great Coach, to use this suffering as an opportunity for training. At times Joseph must have felt discouraged and abandoned, but through his struggle within the limitations of slavery and prison, Joseph grew up; he became complete, mature, and lacked nothing. Then, when the opportunity came, he was able to confidently step forward with his proven and developed abilities. Joseph had potential in the human community based on his antecedents—his energetic matrix, his family background, and his education, etc.—but it was through the long years of struggle that God developed his character.

Here is my translation of Paul’s words of exhortation in First Thessalonians 4:11–12:

Seek honor while living a quiet and restful life. As we instructed you, make it your practice to mind your own business, and productively use your own abilities so that you may walk through your life in a way that wins the respect of outsiders and makes no demands on anyone.

If we waste our energy wishing that we were someone we are not and doing something we are not designed to do, we will leave a gaping hole in the flow of Creation. Our necessary mission will not be fulfilled, and the revelation of God that we were designed to express will be lost. As a result, the whole human community will be crippled by our unwillingness to fulfill our design and our God-directed mission.

Doing the MATH helps us achieve balanced lives of increasing ability and stability. When we can flow out of our oriented, unique design, we can more confidently, and with less effort, maximize our MATH for our mission and for God. Our goal is to be like Jesus, not just through displaying His power and claiming His authority, but by emulating His character and His commitment to doing things God’s way.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, train my courage for the development of my real abilities. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of proven ability that you might develop. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area of proven ability that you might develop*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness without judging it. Just observe. You might notice how you react to this area of proven ability. *(Pause)* You might distrust this ability, or you might not value it. Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider an area of proven ability that you might develop*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* For example, you might recognize what fear of success or fear of hurt pride feels like. You might fear failure. You might even fear making any effort at all. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe the uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of proven ability that you might develop*. What other areas of your MATH might need your attention first? *(Pause)* What might you fear if you were to develop this area of proven ability? Is your story based on past experience or a family system? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling

like you feel when they have *considered an area of proven ability that they might develop*. (Pause) Think about the terrified disciples just after the crucifixion.⁵ You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. (Pause) When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. With compassion for all of us who face this challenge, help your body process with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for training and healing. We want to develop our real abilities for Your purposes and for our own joy and fulfillment. Guide us to our glory and mission as You lead us to the next step in our healing. Help us co-labor with You to train for a more effective flow and a more powerful connection with our True Self and design, with the Creation and our community, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*We are in the NHG season. Be sure to check in with any students that you have invited to the book study and ask how it’s going for them. If you wish to return the gift of facilitation, sign up to help with facilitating at [NHG Facilitator Info](#).

(*Except in the Jubilee Year)

¹ *O Worship the King* by Robert Grant (1779–1838), www.youtube.com/watch?v=RAyKmYD2Zg8.

² www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/56966/speech-all-the-worlds-a-stage.

³ James 1:4.

⁴ Gen. 37, 39–50.

⁵ John 20:19.